

Growing and Curing Sweet Potatoes

A Southern staple from slip to storage

About the Crop

Sweet potatoes (*Ipomoea batatas*) are a foundational Southern food crop and North Carolina is the nation's leading producer. They are productive, store well, and thrive in the warm Piedmont season.

Slips and Planting

- Grow from "slips" — rooted sprouts from a stored sweet potato — or buy certified slips.
- Plant slips after the soil warms and frost danger has passed (mid-to-late May).
- Use loose, well-drained soil or raised ridges; heavy clay should be loosened and mounded.
- Space slips about 12 inches apart on ridges 3–4 feet apart.

Harvest & Curing

Dig before frost, typically 90–120 days after planting, handling the roots gently to avoid bruising. Curing is essential for sweetness and storage:

- Cure at about 80–85°F and high humidity for 7–10 days.
- After curing, store at 55–60°F — never refrigerate raw sweet potatoes.
- Properly cured roots keep for months and grow sweeter in storage.